

Handout: *Harry Frankfurt – “Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility”*

The Problem: Can a person be morally responsible if they could not have done otherwise?

- **Dominant view (The Principle of Alternate Possibilities, or PAP):**
“A person is morally responsible for what they have done only if they could have done otherwise.”
 - This principle has been treated as near self-evident and a *a priori* truth across competing theories of free will and moral responsibility.
 - It seems to express a common moral intuition: If you had no alternatives to choose between, how can you be responsible?
 - **Frankfurt's Thesis: PAP is false.**
A person may be morally responsible even if they *could not have done otherwise*.
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Frankfurt's Strategy: Undermining PAP

Frankfurt doesn't aim to show that **PAP is incoherent**, but rather that it is **irrelevant** to moral responsibility. His goal is *not* to settle the free will/determinism debate but to show that **alternate possibilities are not necessary** for moral responsibility.

I. Background

Incompatibilism

- **Incompatibilists** argue that **if determinism is true**, then no one could have acted otherwise than they did — and thus **no one is morally responsible** for their actions.
- This position rests heavily on the **Principle of Alternate Possibilities (PAP)**:

A person is morally responsible for what they have done only if they could have done otherwise.

- Libertarians (a subset of incompatibilists) believe that **free will requires indeterminism**, while hard determinists accept that determinism rules out free will *and* responsibility.

Compatibilism:

- Compatibilists argue that **free will and determinism can coexist**.
- They typically try to **reinterpret “could have done otherwise”** in a way that doesn't require metaphysical freedom but rather things like internal psychological states, absence of coercion, or rational deliberation.

II. Coercion and PAP: Are they the same issue?

- Frankfurt examines coercion to test PAP:
 - Coercion *does* remove moral responsibility in many cases.
 - But **this isn't because the coerced agent had no alternative**.
 - Rather, **it's because the agent acted because of the coercion**.
 - If the coercion didn't *cause* the action, moral responsibility may still remain.
- Frankfurt's Insight:
 - *“When we excuse a person who has been coerced, we do not excuse him because he was unable to do otherwise.”*

III. The Jones Examples: Clarifying Coercion and Responsibility

Frankfurt introduces a series of hypothetical cases (Jones1–Jones3) to analyze moral responsibility under coercion.

Jones1 – *The Unmoved Agent*

- Decides to act on his own.
- Is threatened afterward, but the threat has no effect.
- He would have acted the same even without the threat.
- **Conclusion:** Clearly morally responsible.

Jones2 – *The Overwhelmed Agent*

- Decides to act, but is then threatened.
- The threat terrifies him; he forgets his decision.

- Acts *only* due to the threat.
- **Conclusion:** Not morally responsible, because **his action is caused by coercion**.

Jones3 – *The Rational Agent with Overdetermined Motivation*

- Decides to act on his own.
- Is then threatened with a harsh consequence.
- He acts *only* on his initial decision, *not* out of fear.
- **Even though he could not have done otherwise**, his action was not *caused* by coercion.
- **Conclusion:** He *is* morally responsible.

Takeaway: The *source* of the action—not the *availability of alternatives*—is what determines responsibility.

IV. The Frankfurt-Style Counterexample (Jones4 and Black)

This is the central thought experiment that undermines PAP.

Setup:

- **Black**, a powerful manipulator, wants **Jones4** to perform a specific action.
- Black will intervene to ensure the action occurs *if* Jones4 starts to decide otherwise.
- But: **Jones4 decides to perform the action on his own**.
 - Black never intervenes.

Key Point:

- Even though **Jones4 *could not have done otherwise*** (Black would have forced him),
- He acted **freely and on his own reasons**.
- Thus, **he is morally responsible**.

“Everything happened just as it would have happened without Black's presence...”

V. What Does “Could Have Done Otherwise” Really Mean?

Frankfurt acknowledges an objection:

- Maybe Jones4 *could* have done otherwise *in a technical sense*—e.g., he could have chosen to defy the threat and suffer consequences.

But Frankfurt replies:

- These senses of “could have done otherwise” don’t matter *morally*, if they don’t explain the *actual cause* of the action.

“The fact that a person could not have avoided doing something... may play no role whatever in the explanation of why he did it.”

VI. Revising PAP

Frankfurt’s **replacement principle**:

A person is not morally responsible for what they have done *if they did it only because they could not have done otherwise.*

This means:

- It’s not the *absence of alternatives* that matters.
- What matters is **whether the action was done *because of that absence.***

Implication:

This revised principle **does not require indeterminism.**

- Moral responsibility is **compatible with determinism**, if people act from their own motives, not *only because* they were causally determined to.
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